the most difficult part, but then again, in my experience, politicians like to talk about their craft—if you are not chasing them for daily deadlines and the short-lived small scoop. I found most of the politicians I spoke to deeply thoughtful about their work, the systems they used and the implications of it all. What we learnt from these wide-ranging conversations greatly enhanced our understanding of the party and its political mobilisation processes.

Interestingly, almost all of my interviews with BJP leaders (barring those from south India) were conducted in Hindi. Almost all senior, mid- and district-level BJP leaders I spoke to in the Hindi belt, including ministers, were monolingual. Hindi is also the language of choice for most of Prime Minister Modi's speeches and for all of Home Minister Amit Shah's speeches. All translations in the book are mine.

My Hindi is pretty good—I began my career as a Hindi TV reporter and anchor, and can type in Hindi—but I still occasionally found some of the usages difficult, especially when it came to technical governance-related terms. This sometimes led to awkward situations. In Mathura, when a district-level BJP leader talked of his party's mahapaur being a Dalit, I asked, 'At what level is a mahapaur?' There was an embarrassed silence. The leader was too polite to laugh, but my journalist colleagues did, even as they informed me that 'mahapaur' means mayor. The point is that almost every BJP leader I met in UP, including two deputy chief ministers, spoke high-order Hindi and did not engage in English at all. This meant that a lot of the work for this book involved translation and the rechecking of specific word meanings and nuances with colleagues whose formal Hindi is better than mine.

Finally, the present can only be understood in the context of the past. Significant parts of this book are drawn from original primary work from three traditional historical archives. The BJP archive at Rambhau Mhalgi Prabodhini, which also serves as the party's political training centre, has kept meticulous records of BJP and RSS literature as well as party documents since the early 1980s. A lot of my understanding of the BJP is drawn from the documents I found there. As far as I know, they were made available for the first time to an outsider for a historical account such as this. Second, in 2018, the